

Chapter 7

Instructor's Manual

This chapter covers:

- The role of film and television entertainment in exposing children to standard language ideology
- A discussion of Jewish and Arab stereotypes in Disney's *The Three Little Pigs* and *Aladdin* respectively
- The strategies Disney employs to decide on character accents in movies that take place in other countries and how Disney situates its movies in time and space
- A description of the methodology and results of a study of full-length animated Disney films that explores how accents are used in ways that help socialize children to stereotypes and prejudice.

Sample answers to the questions from the text and the website

From the textbook

1. Compile a list of Disney characters who speak English with a clear Anglo-New York City area accent. What do these characters have in common? Look at sociocultural characteristics, personality traits, motivations, style, and role in the plot. How do your findings support or contradict the idea that stereotype does not have to be overtly negative to be limiting and prejudicial?

Sample answer: I can think of two animated Disney characters that speak with an Anglo-New York City area accent: Mittens from *Bolt* (voiced by Susie Essman), and Terk from *Tarzan* (voiced by Rosie O'Donnell). Both of these characters are tough, smart-aleck sidekicks. These limited findings do support the idea that a stereotype does not have to be overtly negative to be limiting and prejudicial. By representing speakers of New York English as smart-aleck sidekicks, these movies send kids the message that speakers of New York accented English might be tough, funny, and loyal friends, but they are never princesses, heroes, heroines, or love interests. Restricting the representation of any group to such a narrow scope sends the message to children that the options in life for such speakers are limited.

2. Murnane (2007) proposes that Disney films can be used in the classroom to teach multiculturalism (<http://www.historycooperative.org/journals/whc/5.1/murnane.html>). Choose one of the Disney animated films and outline a middle school lesson plan that would accomplish such a goal. Be sure to include some aspect of language use and accent manipulation. Be sure to cite the sources of your information.

Sample answer: I would have the students break into small groups and choose between *Mulan* or *Aladdin* for their project. Then, I would have the group write a brief summary of the movie as well as a description of each character, including that character's appearance, accent, and role in the movie. I would also ask the students to analyze any stereotypes they see in the film from an

initial critical viewing. After identifying the major stereotypes in the movie, I would have them do research to explore information about the culture being depicted in the movie and write an analytical paper in which they discuss the stereotypes in the movie in light of what they have learned from their research.

3. Read “*Demonizing in Children’s Television Cartoons and Disney Animated Films*,” a short quantitative study of the concept of evil in Disney films (Fouts et al. 2006). How do the findings of this paper contradict or support the data and conclusions drawn in this chapter?

Sample answer: This study supports the conclusions drawn in this chapter because it focuses on how children’s perceptions of the world are influenced by repeated viewings of Disney movies (as well as animated television programs). This study suggests that young children may learn how to demonize others in stereotypical ways from Disney movies, which is similar to the conclusions in this chapter which suggest that children learn stereotypes about speakers of different language varieties from Disney movies.

4. Consider the way you and others talk about Disney. Do you hear phrases such as “allowances have to be made for the times,” or “that’s the way things were,” or “everybody felt that way,” or “come on, it’s supposed to be funny”? Where do such reactions originate, and are they meant to move discussion forward, or to shut down discourse and critical analysis? For close readings of examples of this kind of reasoning, see especially Hill (2008).

Sample answer: I have heard people make excuses for the racism in Disney films by either accepting it because the film was made in the past when overt racism was more acceptable or deriding critics by accusing them of ruining the comedy and fun in movies with their political correctness. I think both of these responses are meant to shut down discourse and critical reaction. Perhaps the people who say these kinds of things love the Disney movies so much that they feel uncomfortable recognizing that a movie they have always been fond of is laced with racist and sexist messages. Or perhaps speaking about racism makes them feel uncomfortable in general so they want to shut down the conversation. Or, it could be that these people subconsciously (or consciously) enjoy the social status quo and do not want to encourage critical analysis that would lead to social change.

From the website

Audio

1. Listen to the variety of accents mentioned in Chapter 7. Reflect on the stereotypes that connect to these accents. Why do you think these accents are used the way they are in animated Disney films? For example, why would French accents be used for sexy chambermaids, chefs and waiters? Why do the heroes speak Standard American English? Why do so many sidekicks speak AAVE or urban varieties of English rather than *SAE?

Sample answer: I think these accents are used the way they are to connect to stereotypes associated with the people who speak with those accents. For example, I think that French accents are used by sexy chambermaids and chefs because many Americans have a stereotype of

the French as being sexy foodies. I would posit that many sidekicks speak AAVE or an urban dialect of English rather than *SAE because of stereotypes that depict people who speak AAVE and urban dialects as funny, street-smart, wise-cracking, and loyal. These traits are all pretty positive, but they are not the same traits that might be associated with the *SAE-speaking hero: brave, just, moral, kind problem-solvers. In addition, due to standard language ideology, many Americans would likely expect a hero to speak *SAE rather than a devalued variety. Disney is not casting actors for these roles randomly – it is casting actors and asking them to speak a certain way in order to draw on the audience’s previously existing stereotypes to establish a character.

Video

“A Disney First”

CBS News

<http://www.cbsnews.com/video/watch/?id=5073930n>

1. Based on the reporting in this clip and what you have learned in Chapter 7, in what ways has Disney’s representation of African Americans changed? In what ways has Disney’s approach remained the same?

Sample answer: In many ways, I think this movie indicates a positive change for Disney. The heroine is African American and uses AAVE pronunciations, which breaks the pattern of *SAE-speaking heroines in previous movies. In addition, the hero/love interest is not Anglo, which is very unusual in Disney movies. However, this movie also shows that Disney still has much room for improvement. For example, the main character was originally going to be a maid rather than a restaurant server. While employment opportunities were restricted for African American women in the 1920s, the audience for this movie is too young to understand the history of institutionalized racism in this country that caused many African American women to work as maids. In addition, African Americans were often restricted to roles as servants in films for white audiences in the past, so I am suspicious of Disney’s original choice of occupation for the heroine. Also, while Tiana does use AAVE pronunciations, she does not use any grammatical constructions of AAVE, which perhaps sends the message to children that AAVE varieties that are closest to *SAE are acceptable, but varieties that are further from *SAE are not.

2. What do you think about Disney’s decision to have a Brazilian prince instead of an African American prince in this movie?

Sample answer: I have conflicting feelings about this issue. On one hand, I think it’s cool to have an interracial relationship in a Disney movie to show kids that there is nothing wrong with interracial relationships. On the other hand, I am suspicious about their motives in deciding not to have an African American prince. I am also suspicious about their choice of accent for the prince. I haven’t seen this movie, but in the clips I saw online, the prince appears to present himself (even in frog form!) as being quite the ladies man, a character trait that corresponds to stereotypes of sexy, steamy, Brazilian men. If this is an accurate depiction of the character of the prince, then I would worry about the use of the Brazilian accent to introduce children to this stereotype as well.

Suggested activities and discussion questions

1. Have your students extend the author's research to more recent Disney films or to other animated films or television shows for children. What trends do your students see in other animated movies and shows? In what ways do their findings support or contradict the material presented in this chapter? What messages are children getting about language variation from these animated films and shows?
2. Ask your students to reflect on the covert messages children get from animated films about people who speak certain language varieties. What can parents of young children do to combat these messages?
3. Find out which of your students watched Disney animated films when growing up. For those who did, which films were their favorites? Did they ever notice any stereotypes or the connections between linguistic variation and social stereotypes in the films when they were kids? If they did notice, what did they think at the time? If they did not notice, why do they think they didn't, and what might that tell them about their budding language ideologies as children?
4. To enhance discussion of this chapter, please visit the companion website and check out the audio and video clips available for use in your classroom.